

The Law of Life

Jack London · 1901

First published: McClure's, Mar 1901

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Children_of_the_Frost/The_Law_of_Life (revision 3806232), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 8–11 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Law of Life suggest about the cycle of life and death?
- What does The Law of Life suggest about age and community?
- What does The Law of Life suggest about acceptance?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Law of Life	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*the cycle of life and death* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Law of Life

Focus: accepting one's place in nature's cycle

Content note (an elder left to die, wolves): Sensitive content: An elder left to die; wolves. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes an elder left to die; wolves.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Old Koskoosh, blind and frail, is left by his tribe beside a small fire with a pile of sticks as they move camp in the Arctic winter, as custom requires. He remembers the old moose he once watched wolves bring down and accepts that nature cares only for the race, not the individual. When his fire dies, wolves close in; he lets the firebrand fall.

Background: Published in McClure's in 1901 and collected in Children of the Frost (1902). London draws on, and generalizes, accounts of Indigenous Yukon peoples; teachers should discuss this outsider's perspective.

Significance: A compact statement of London's naturalism, paired often with To Build a Fire.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: How should a community care for its oldest members? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes an elder left to die; wolves.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are numbness, crouched, retreated, footing, obedient. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "First his feet would yield, then his hands; and the numbness would travel, slowly, from the extremities to the body." In this sentence it means: partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Law of Life would have known. Published in McClure's in 1901 and collected in Children of the Frost (1902). London draws on, and generalizes, accounts of Indigenous Yukon peoples; teachers should discuss this outsider's perspective. Why does this story matter? A compact statement of London's naturalism, paired often with To Build a Fire. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for setting.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "He bowed his head in content till the last noise of the complaining snow had died away, and he knew his son was beyond recall." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to accepting one's place in nature's cycle? I circle "numbness", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find setting, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for setting.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of setting. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *He bowed his head in content till the last noise of the complaining snow had died away, and he knew his son was beyond recall. Then his hand crept out in haste to the wood. It alone stood between him and the eternity that yawned in upon him. At last the measure of his life was a handful of fagots. One by one they would go to feed the fire, and just so, step by step, death would creep upon him. When the last stick had surrendered up its heat, the frost would begin to gather strength. First his feet would yield, then his hands; and the numbness would travel, slowly, from the extremities to the body. His head would fall forward upon his knees, and he would rest. It was easy. All men must die.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Setting, Theme, Imagery: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Law of Life develops the idea of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and theme shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to the cycle of life and death? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about accepting one's place in nature's cycle, backed by one short quotation.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how setting shapes accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
numbness (noun)	partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction	*First his feet would yield, then his hands; and the numbness would travel, slowly, from the extremities to the body.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
crouched (verb)	bend one's back forward from the waist on down	*There was the time of the Great Famine, when the old men crouched empty-bellied to the fire, and let fall from their lips dim traditions of the ancient day when the Yukon ran wide open for three winters, and then lay frozen for three summers.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
retreated (verb)	pull back or move away or backward	*Overcome for the nonce by his hereditary fear of man, the brute retreated, raising a prolonged call to his brothers; and greedily they answered, till a ring of crouching, jaw-slobbered gray was stretched round about.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
footing (noun)	the terms of a relationship; one's position	*Twice had he been dragged down, as the snow attested, and twice had he shaken his assailants clear and gained footing once more.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
obedient (adjective)	dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority	*Nature did not care; there were plenty who were obedient, and it was only the obedience in this matter, not the obedient, which lived and lived always.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
revived (verb)	came back to life; returned	*Then it was the men became high-stomached, and revived ancient quarrels, and crossed the divides to the south to kill the Pellys, and to the west that they might sit by the dead fires of the Tananas.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
wonders (noun)	the feeling aroused by something strange and surprising	*The shaman would see signs and wonders in this when they told him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
concern (noun)	worry and sympathy	*She had no concern for that concrete thing called the individual.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How should a community care for its oldest members?

2. Where does setting appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with the cycle of life and death?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why is Koskoosh left behind? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He is too old and weak to travel with the tribe
2. What is left with him? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A small fire and a pile of sticks
3. Who leads the tribe now? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: His son, the chief
4. What memory does Koskoosh recall? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Wolves bringing down an old moose
5. What does 'the law of life' mean in the story? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Nature cares for the race, not the individual
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Law of Life” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Old Koskoosh, blind and frail, is left by his tribe beside a small fire with a pile of sticks as they move camp in the Arctic winter, as custom requires. He remembers the old moose he once watched wolves bring down and accepts that nature cares only for the race, not the individual. When his fire dies, wolves close in; he lets the firebrand fall.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Law of Life”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Law of Life” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “First his feet would yield, then his hands; and the numbness would travel, slowly, from the extremities to the body.” What does “numbness” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: numbness: partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction.
10. Reread: “There was the time of the Great Famine, when the old men crouched empty-bellied to the fire, and let fall from their lips dim traditions of the ancient day when the Yukon ran wide open for three winters, and then lay…” What does “crouched” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: crouched: bend one's back forward from the waist on down.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Law of Life” suggest about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A compact statement of London's naturalism, paired often with To Build a Fire.
2. Find one example of setting in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
3. How does the theme in this story shape what we understand about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas.
4. In the passage that begins “He bowed his head in content till the last noise of the complaining snow had died away, and he knew his son was beyond recall.”, why might London have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Law of Life”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Old Koskoosh, blind and frail, is left by his tribe beside a small fire with a pile of sticks as they move camp in the Arctic winter, as custom requires. He remembers the old moose he once watched wolves bring down and accepts that nature cares only for the race, not the individual. When his fire…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Law of Life” set up that the rest of The Law of Life will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How should a community care for its oldest members?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with the cycle of life and death? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
10. Background: Published in McClure's in 1901 and collected in Children of the Frost (1902). London draws on, and generalizes, accounts of Indigenous Yukon peoples; teachers should discuss this outsider's perspective. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A compact statement of London's naturalism, paired often with To Build a Fire.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

3. Rewrite one moment of “The Law of Life” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Law of Life”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to age and community: is the link strong or weak so far? What would London need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the setting in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how “The Law of Life” treats accepting one's place in nature's cycle with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Law of Life see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve the cycle of life and death? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about accepting one's place in nature's cycle? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Jack London about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Theme**: statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz

1. Why is Koskoosh left behind?
   A. He is being punished
   B. He is too old and weak to travel with the tribe
   C. He chooses to hunt
   D. He is sick with plague
2. What is left with him?
   A. A rifle
   B. A sled
   C. A small fire and a pile of sticks

D. Food for a month

3. Who leads the tribe now?
   A. His son, the chief
   B. A trader
   C. His granddaughter
   D. A shaman
4. What memory does Koskoosh recall?
   A. His wedding
   B. Wolves bringing down an old moose
   C. His first trade
   D. A great flood
5. What does 'the law of life' mean in the story?
   A. Always obey the chief
   B. Nature cares for the race, not the individual
   C. Never be alone
   D. Fire protects life
6. In the line “First his feet would yield, then his hands; and the numbness would travel, slowly, from the extremities to the body.”, what does “numbness” most nearly mean?
   A. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
   B. pull back or move away or backward
   C. partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction
   D. the terms of a relationship; one's position
7. In the line “There was the time of the Great Famine, when the old men crouched empty-bellied to the fire, and let fall from their lips dim traditions of the ancient day when the Yukon ran wide open for three winters, and then lay frozen for three summers.”, what does “crouched” most nearly mean?
   A. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
   B. pull back or move away or backward
   C. partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction
   D. the terms of a relationship; one's position

Answer key: 1. B (He is too old and weak to travel with the tribe); 2. C (A small fire and a pile of sticks); 3. A (His son, the chief); 4. B (Wolves bringing down an old moose); 5. B (Nature cares for the race, not the individual); 6. C (partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction); 7. A (bend one's back forward from the waist on down)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Law of Life,” how does London show accepting one's place in nature's cycle?

Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Law of Life, how does London develop the idea of accepting one's place in nature's cycle? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Law of Life develops the idea of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and theme shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Law of Life (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Law of Life suggests about accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's setting and theme), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Jack London uses setting in The Law of Life to complicate the reader's understanding of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Law of Life within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of accepting one's place in nature's cycle responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Law of Life alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of accepting one's place in nature's cycle follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Law of Life and its treatment of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's setting and theme, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Law of Life as evidence for a larger claim about accepting one's place in nature's cycle in The Law of Life. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Law of Life as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of accepting one's place in nature's cycle. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Law of Life.

SAT-style questions

1. *Overcome for the nonce by his hereditary fear of man, the brute retreated, raising a prolonged call to his brothers; and greedily they answered, till a ring of crouching, jaw-slobbered gray was stretched round about.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “retreated” most nearly mean?

   A. pull back or move away or backward

   B. the feeling aroused by something strange and surprising

   C. came back to life; returned

   D. worry and sympathy

2. *He bowed his head in content till the last noise of the complaining snow had died away, and he knew his son was beyond recall. Then his hand crept out in haste to the wood. It alone stood between him and the eternity that yawned in upon him. At last the measure of his life was a handful of fagots. One by one they would go to feed the fire, and just so, step by step, death would creep upon him. When the last stick had surrendered up its heat, the frost would begin to gather strength. First his feet would yield, then his hands; and the numbness would travel, slowly, from the extremities to the body. His head would fall forward upon his knees, and he would rest. It was easy. All men must die.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Law of Life”?

   A. Revenge carried out with perfect control

   B. A choice the reader must make

   C. Endurance turning to justice

   D. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

SAT key: 1. A (pull back or move away or backward); 2. D (Accepting one's place in nature's cycle)

Whole-book test

The Law of Life: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Why is Koskoosh left behind?
   A. He is being punished
   B. He is too old and weak to travel with the tribe
   C. He chooses to hunt
   D. He is sick with plague
2. What is left with him?
   A. A rifle
   B. A sled
   C. A small fire and a pile of sticks
   D. Food for a month
3. Who leads the tribe now?
   A. His son, the chief
   B. A trader
   C. His granddaughter
   D. A shaman
4. What memory does Koskoosh recall?
   A. His wedding
   B. Wolves bringing down an old moose
   C. His first trade
   D. A great flood
5. What does 'the law of life' mean in the story?
   A. Always obey the chief
   B. Nature cares for the race, not the individual
   C. Never be alone
   D. Fire protects life
6. In the line “First his feet would yield, then his hands; and the numbness would travel, slowly, from the extremities to the body.”, what does “numbness” most nearly mean?
   A. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
   B. pull back or move away or backward
   C. partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction
   D. the terms of a relationship; one's position

7. In the line “There was the time of the Great Famine, when the old men crouched empty-bellied to the fire, and let fall from their lips dim traditions of the ancient day when the Yukon ran wide open for three winters, and then lay frozen for three summers.”, what does “crouched” most nearly mean?
   A. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
   B. pull back or move away or backward
   C. partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction
   D. the terms of a relationship; one's position
8. As used in the story (“First his feet would yield, then his hands; and the numbness would travel, slowly, from the extremities to the body.”), what does “numbness” mean?
   A. partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction
   B. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority
   C. worry and sympathy
   D. the terms of a relationship; one's position
9. As used in the story (“There was the time of the Great Famine, when the old men crouched empty-bellied to the fire, and let fall from their lips dim traditions of ”), what does “crouched” mean?
   A. came back to life; returned
   B. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
   C. partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction
   D. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority
10. As used in the story (“Overcome for the nonce by his hereditary fear of man, the brute retreated, raising a prolonged call to his brothers; and greedily they answe”), what does “retreated” mean?
    A. the feeling aroused by something strange and surprising
    B. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
    C. pull back or move away or backward
    D. came back to life; returned
11. As used in the story (“Twice had he been dragged down, as the snow attested, and twice had he shaken his assailants clear and gained footing once more.”), what does “footing” mean?
    A. worry and sympathy
    B. pull back or move away or backward
    C. the feeling aroused by something strange and surprising
    D. the terms of a relationship; one's position
12. As used in the story (“Nature did not care; there were plenty who were obedient, and it was only the obedience in this matter, not the obedient, which lived and li”), what does “obedient” mean?
    A. dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority
    B. partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction
    C. the terms of a relationship; one's position
    D. worry and sympathy

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how the cycle of life and death develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how age and community develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how acceptance develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (the cycle of life and death, age and community, acceptance) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. B (He is too old and weak to travel with the tribe); 2. C (A small fire and a pile of sticks); 3. A (His son, the chief); 4. B (Wolves bringing down an old moose); 5. B (Nature cares for the race, not the individual); 6. C (partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction); 7. A (bend one's back forward from the waist on down); 8. A (partial or total lack of sensation in a part of the body; a symptom of nerve damage or dysfunction); 9. B (bend one's back forward from the waist on down); 10. C (pull back or move away or backward); 11. D (the terms of a relationship; one's position); 12. A (dutifully complying with the commands or instructions of those in authority)

Essay assignments

Essay: The cycle of life and death

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Law of Life teaches about the cycle of life and death. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jack London develops the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jack London develops the cycle of life and death across The Law of Life. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Law of Life (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the cycle of life and death. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jack London's choices in The Law of Life (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the cycle of life and death, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Law of Life's treatment of the cycle of life and death in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the cycle of life and death in The Law of Life, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Age and community

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Law of Life teaches about age and community. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jack London develops age and community in The Law of Life. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jack London develops age and community across The Law of Life. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Law of Life (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of age and community. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of age and community in The Law of Life. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jack London's choices in The Law of Life (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of age and community, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Law of Life's treatment of age and community in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on age and community in The Law of Life that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on age and community in The Law of Life. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about age and community in The Law of Life, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on age and community in The Law of Life, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Acceptance

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Law of Life teaches about acceptance. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jack London develops acceptance in The Law of Life. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jack London develops acceptance across The Law of Life. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Law of Life (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of acceptance. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of acceptance in The Law of Life. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jack London's choices in The Law of Life (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of acceptance, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Law of Life's treatment of acceptance in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on acceptance in The Law of Life that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on acceptance in The Law of Life. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about acceptance in The Law of Life, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on acceptance in The Law of Life, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.